

RESEARCH ARTICLE

Organizations' engagement with sustainable development goals: From cherry-picking to SDG-washing?

Iñaki Heras-Saizarbitoria¹  | Laida Urbieta² | Olivier Boiral³

¹Department of Management, University of the Basque Country UPV-EHU, San Sebastian, Spain

²Department of Financial Economics I, University of the Basque Country UPV-EHU, San Sebastian, Spain

³Department of Management, Université Laval, Québec, Canada

Correspondence

Iñaki Heras-Saizarbitoria, Faculty of Economics and Business, Department of Management, University of the Basque Country UPV-EHU, Oñati Plaza 1, 20018, San Sebastian, Spain.
Email: iheras@ehu.eus

Abstract

This article analyzes the organizational engagement with the United Nations sustainable development goals (SDGs), an initiative for corporate social responsibility also referred to as the 2030 Agenda. Engagement with the SDGs by organizations all around the world, whatever their sector and size, has attracted a lot of media interest and heightened expectations. Nevertheless, there is a lack of empirical work that sheds light on the commitment to this initiative at the organizational level. In order to fill this gap, this article examines the characteristics of engagement with the SDGs of 1370 organizations from 97 countries, taking data from their sustainability reports. The study looks at how and why organizations engage with the SDGs, as well as the priority they assign to them. The findings point to a superficial engagement with the SDGs for the vast majority of organizations, which suggests a process of “SDG-washing”. Implications for managers, public policy makers and other stakeholders are analyzed.

KEYWORDS

2030 agenda, Bluewashing, SDGs, SDG-washing, sustainability reporting, sustainable development goals

1 | INTRODUCTION

The 2030 Agenda launched by the United Nations (UN) in 2015 includes 17 overarching sustainable development goals (SDGs), 169 related targets and more than 230 associated indicators (Bennich et al., 2020). Organizations' commitment to the SDGs is enthusiastically highlighted in the practitioner (e.g., Giddens, 2020) and scholarly (e.g., Pedersen, 2018) literature as a way to promote Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and sustainable development.

Yet, little is known about the real dissemination and the progress towards SDGs at the organizational level. In a survey conducted by Accenture (2020) with more than 1000 CEOs from more than 100 countries and 25 industries, close to 90% of the respondents associated SDGs with an opportunity to rethink organizational

approaches to sustainable value creation, and 70% thought that the SDGs provided a clear framework to structure sustainability efforts, but no information was given regarding the organizational engagement with the SDGs. A study by PwC (2020), including data from 986 businesses, found that 71% of the organizations mentioned that they were already planning their responses to the SDGs. In a recent academic study focusing on large multinational corporations (MNCs) from the financial times stock exchange (FTSE), Silva (2021) found that 67% of organizations reported on SDGs. In contrast with that, Waal and Thijssens (2020) pointed to a much more limited figure: only 23% of the companies (39% of the companies studied that published a sustainability report) mentioned the SDGs in their reports. Similarly, many previous works (e.g., Curtó-Pagès et al., 2021; Elalfy et al., 2021) conducted a macro- and country-level analysis of commitment to the

This is an open access article under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs License, which permits use and distribution in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, the use is non-commercial and no modifications or adaptations are made.

© 2021 The Authors. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management* published by ERP Environment and John Wiley & Sons Ltd.

SDGs or explored the factors that influence commitment to the SDGs, mostly using SDG reporting as a proxy for commitment.

In the scholarly fields of business and management, a broad-scope initiative such as the 2030 and Agenda SDGs¹ may be associated with voluntary self-regulation initiatives for CSR based on public-private partnership and launched as a reaction to alleged environmental and societal concerns about corporations (Macellari et al., 2021; Spraul & Thaler, 2019). The UN launched several more business-oriented CSR initiatives in this field, such as the UN Global Compact (UNGC) launched in 1999, the UN Guiding Principles for Business and Human Rights launched in 2011, and the broader initiative of eight Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) launched in 2000 with 2015 as the goal-horizon. Like the SDGs, these initiatives had their own momentum. For example, the UNGC attracted very optimistic attention in both the practitioner and scholarly literature (e.g., Kell, 2005; Williams, 2004), but it was also associated with the phenomenon of bluewashing (e.g., Berliner & Prakash, 2015; Garayar et al., 2016).

Corporate engagement and progress on SDGs may be analyzed by specific indicators consistent with these goals and the main sustainability reporting frameworks, particularly the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI; Berliner & Prakash, 2015; Macellari et al., 2021), which have been extensively studied in the CSR field (e.g., Alonso-Almeida et al., 2014; Chiarini, 2017; Moratis & Brandt, 2017), despite increasing questions about the reliability of this type of reporting (e.g., Boiral, 2013; Cho et al., 2010; Diouf & Boiral, 2017; Moneva et al., 2006). Indeed, sustainability reporting has been identified as an enabler of SDG actions, investments and strategies (Rosati & Faria, 2019a), and the GRI has been indicated as a useful framework for the operationalization of the SDGs (Diaz-Sarachaga, 2021; Ordonez-Ponce & Khare, 2021).

Nevertheless, the scholarly literature based on empirical studies is at a very early and underdeveloped stage. Practitioners and scholars have highlighted the lack of knowledge about the specific role of organizations in addressing SDGs and the real impact of this initiative on their practice. A report by Oxfam commented on the lack of “reliable information on how companies are working to contribute to the SDGs” (Mhlanga et al., 2018, p. 1). In the scholarly field, Caiado et al. (2018), Mio et al. (2020) and Bennich et al. (2020) reviewed academic articles and provided evidence of a lack of detailed information on how organizations engage with SDGs. Bebbington and Unerman (2018), and Van der Waal and Thijssens (2020) noted the lack of empirical studies and general understanding of corporate commitment to the SDGs. Considering this gap in both the practitioner and scholarly literatures, the present work aims to shed light on the characteristics of engagement with the SDGs by organizations from different countries, based on the analysis of their sustainability reports.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. First, in the next section, the literature review and the research question are presented. Second, the method of the analysis carried out in the field work is described. Third, the results of the analysis are summarized. Fourth, the discussion and the conclusions are set out, together with the original contribution, the limitations of the work and avenues for further research.

2 | LITERATURE REVIEW AND RESEARCH QUESTION

Self-regulation is an umbrella term for initiatives led by different private bodies such as industrial associations, NGOs and global institutions (e.g., UN, ISO) in very diverse fields, such as CSR and corporate environmental management. These bodies set private rules and standards—also referred to as *soft law*—to regulate organizational behavior in an alternative way to traditional public regulation—or *hard law* (Haufler, 2000; Heras-Saizarbitoria & Boiral, 2013; King & Lenox, 2000; Spraul & Thaler, 2019; Vogel, 2008). From the perspective of neo-institutional theory, organizations tackle social and environmental issues, such as those included in the UNGC and SDGs mainly in the pursuit legitimacy (Boiral et al., 2017; Macellari et al., 2021). Organizations seek support and legitimacy in the eyes of their stakeholders and adopt practices that are perceived to be rational and legitimate. The adoption of SDGs contributes to the social license to operate of organizations (Demuijnck & Fasterling, 2016). From this theoretical perspective, organizations engage with the SDGs primarily to respond to institutional pressures—a key research issue for the neo-institutional approach—and to reinforce organizational legitimacy, rather than to significantly improve CSR and sustainability practices and performance (Boiral, 2013).

This type of reputational management has often been associated with greenwashing (Boiral et al., 2017; Heras-Saizarbitoria et al., 2020; Testa et al., 2018). In the case of the UNGC initiative in self-regulation, a specific term was coined—namely bluewashing, referring to the blue UN flag. Bluewashing describes a smokescreen of practices used for purposes of public relations (Berliner & Prakash, 2015; Rasche, 2009). Very few empirical studies have analyzed such activities (Garayar et al., 2016; Macellari et al., 2021), and most research has focused on non-empirical reflection on the business case for SDGs. For example, Bebbington and Unerman (2018) pointed out that SDGs could be used “to camouflage business-as-usual by disguising it using SDG-related sustainability rhetoric” (p. 10). Indeed, terms such as rainbow-washing and SDG-washing have been coined in the academic literature (e.g., Beyne, 2020; Izzo et al., 2020; Moratis & Melissen, 2018), referring to the symbolic rather than substantive commitment to SDGs. These terms have also entered the practitioner literature (e.g., Gresko & Banik, 2016; Sullivan, 2018).

The few empirical studies of organizational engagement with the SDGs that have been conducted can be classified in two groups. First, the major group includes studies that analyze the determinants of SDG engagement, using SDG reporting as a proxy for the engagement. These group of studies do not focus on the organizational level to scrutinize the engagement with SDGs. For example, Rosati and Faria (2019a) found that only 67 out of the 408 organizations that they studied had made reference to the SDGs in the sustainability reports published in 2016. These authors shed light on the relationship between organizational characteristics and SDG reporting. Those characteristics included such size, intangible assets and commitment to various sustainability frameworks. In a complementary work, these researchers analyzed the relationship between SDG reporting and a set of institutional factors, and found that organizations that report on

SDGs are more likely to be located in countries that are vulnerable to climate change (Rosati & Faria, 2019b). Similarly, van der Waal and Thijssens (2020) used logistic and quantile regressions to associate organizational attributes with commitment to the SDGs based on a sample of large, stock-listed firms worldwide. Finally, Pizzi et al. (2021) analyzed the sustainability reports of 153 Italian Public Interest Entities and found a positive relationship between reporting on SDGs and a number of determinants, including the presence of independent directors on the board and organizational expertise with non-financial reporting.

In the second group of studies, a number of recent works have focused on the organizational level to analyze the engagement with SDGs. Van Zanten and Van Tulder (2018) conducted a survey of 81 large MNCs from Europe and North America, and found that companies are more likely to engage with SDG targets relevant to their own value chain operations, and with targets that “avoid harm” rather than “do good.” Other scattered works analyzed indirectly organizational engagement with SDGs through limited case-studies (e.g., Battaglia et al., 2020; Mansell et al., 2020; Vildåsen, 2018). For example, Battaglia et al. (2020) analyzed the operational dimensions of the SDGs for the case of a large Italian energy company. A set of relevant works were also focused on SDG reporting to scrutinize the organizational engagement with the goals. Avramiou et al. (2019) analyzed the SDG reporting by five leading European banks and found that they had very diverse approaches, but little overall impact. Van der Waal and Thijssens (2020) also analyzed qualitatively the disclosure of the 30 organizations identified as the most comprehensive SDG reporters. They found that organizations have only a superficial engagement with SDGs; they describe the SDGs in broad terms, remain silent on specific actions taken, and avoiding the measurement and operationalization of SDGs (van der Waal & Thijssens, 2020). The authors point to the use of impression management techniques by organizations, and their largely symbolic rather than substantive engagement with SDGs (van der Waal & Thijssens, 2020). Similarly, Silva (2021) analyzed deductively the contributions to the SDGs of 67 large MNCs from the FTSE 100 and found that these firms legitimize their contributions by matching the SDGs to their actual activities or by using the SDGs as inspiration for their future activities. Silva also points to a symbolic rather than substantive approach to SDG engagement by organizations, in response to pressure from external stakeholders.

Macellari et al. (2021) carried out a content analysis of a sample of sustainability reports published by 28 organizations included in the UNGC LEAD, a program launched in 2010 for an exclusive group of firms that have demonstrated leadership in SDG issues and excellent communication practices. The researchers juxtaposed the information disclosed in the reports with information from external sources and therefore not controlled by the organizations studied. The analysis revealed that more than 80% of significant negative events were not reported or only partially reported, and the authors were left with an impression that the firms had been bluewashing.

From the practitioner field, in a report published by Oxfam—an international confederation of NGOs—Mhlanga et al. (2018) analyzed companies' commitment to the SDGs based on a review of public

information disclosed by 76 of the world's largest firms. The analysis outlined the following key concerns:

1. Companies have no consistent approach to establishing their SDG priorities;
2. The SDGs do not substantially modified corporate approaches to sustainability;
3. SDG engagement does not significantly improve corporate sustainability strategies;
4. Despite the increased awareness of companies, SDG reporting remains limited.

The authors conclude that companies' engagement with the SDGs must substantially improve if they are to play a meaningful role in achieving the SDGs, as for many organizations the goals will otherwise only be a tool for public relations (Mhlanga et al., 2018). The authors underlined a possible trend towards SDG-washing, with companies “cherry-picking” the SDGs that they feel comfortable with. They called for more effective business engagement and more meaningful action in this area, and argued that organizations should consider SDG prioritization and SDG integration or operationalization, in order to improve their SDG-related communication and deepen their SDG engagement (Mhlanga et al., 2018).

By SDG prioritization, Mhlanga et al. (2018) meant the specification of which SDGs the company prioritized and why, on the basis of meaningful, internal, organizational reflection, for example, with a public explanation of what is considered relevant—or material²—and which stakeholders were consulted (Mhlanga et al., 2018). Research on SDGs carried out from a general public policy perspective has underlined the holistic and indivisible nature of the SDGs, and a large number of potential interactions and synergies among goals and targets (e.g., Forestier & Kim, 2020; Pradhan et al., 2017). Policy makers have to consider the goals as a whole, but goal prioritization may be appropriate when considering diverse contexts and capabilities (Forestier & Kim, 2020). This is especially important at the more concrete level of organizations. Indeed, Mhlanga et al. (2018) suggested that the meaningful prioritization of SDGs might be interpreted as a proxy for internal reflection and integration of the goals. Conversely, a superficial, unreasoned and unshared prioritization might be identified as cherry-picking, with organizations focusing on unproblematic goals. Forestier and Kim (2020) identified cherry-picking as a major challenge for national policy makers and international institutions, while Louise Scott (2017), the Global Sustainability Director of PwC UK, said, “It's less about picking the easiest, most obvious or positive ones, and more about picking the ones that are material to the business or have the greatest negative impact.” But as many organizations use impression management techniques (Diouf & Boiral, 2017), it might be hard to scrutinize this issue. Siegel and Lima (2020, p. 1) suggest that, “Organizations now employ metonymy as a tactic, cherry-picking preferred goals or targets as a sign of supposed adherence to the whole 2030 Agenda.” Although many stakeholders may see this approach as falling well short of the underlying ethos of the SDGs (Jones et al., 2016), it is a foreseeable approach. Furthermore,

emphasis could also be placed on the potential trend for organizations to cherry-pick among their current activities to assign them to specific SDGs. As a practitioner interviewed by Siegel and Lima (2020) declared, “I have not seen companies use [the SDGs] in any meaningful way, but simply cherry-pick what is interesting for what they already do” (Siegel & Lima, 2020, p. 6).

SDG integration or operationalization means the use of SDGs to guiding companies' actions in their sustainability strategies (Mhlanga et al., 2018). This is related to the “how” of SDG engagement (Silva, 2021). SDGs might be integrated or operationalized in the organization in a measurable, accountable and assessable manner, with adequate monitoring and assessment systems in place. Reporting frameworks such as those proposed by GRI and the SDG Action Manager—a free web-based tool produced by the UNGC—or the SDG Compass—a guide developed by the UN Global Compact, the GRI and the World Business Council for Sustainable Development detailing the steps companies should take to align their strategy with the SDGs—might be valuable (Garcia-Sanchez et al., 2020; Montiel et al., 2021), but perhaps not sufficient. Recent scholarly works focusing on specific SDGs have stressed the importance of framing SDG assessment with more detailed target- and performance-centered schemes. For example, Johnsson et al. (2020) proposed a specific framework for SDG 13 (Climate action) and underlined the importance of framing SDG assessments in a way that discourages SDG-washing.

With the aim of this article in mind, and based on the theoretical and empirical considerations found in the scholarly literature, the following main research question is proposed: *Why and how do organizations engage with the 2030 Agenda considering (1) their general motivation towards SDGs, (2) the prioritization of SDGs, and (3) the integration and operationalization of SDGs?*

3 | METHODS

In order to address the research question, an exploratory empirical study was performed, based on a qualitative in-depth analysis of sustainability reports published by organizations that claim to be committed to the SDGs. As van der Waal and Thijssens (2020) point out, the focus on sustainability reporting is justified (1) by the importance given by the SDGs to this activity, as established in SDG Target 12.6 and (2) by the expectation that companies consciously engaging with the SDGs will communicate this positive aspect in their sustainability reports, as suggested in the accounting literature (e.g., Bansal et al., 2014; Patten, 2002).

Organizations reporting using the GRI framework are considered more likely to report on the SDGs as well (Curtó-Pagès et al., 2021). As van der Waal and Thijssens (2020) suggest, it seems likely that most of the leading SDG reporters will use the GRI guidelines. This framework has also recently included a reference field to signal an “explicit reference” to SDGs by organizations (GRI, 2020), so companies that claim a commitment to SDGs may be differentiated from those that do not.

Therefore, the sample of reporting organizations was limited to those with this “explicit reference” to SDGs in their verified reports³ disclosed under the more recent standards, namely the GRI G4 Guidelines or the GRI Standards Reporting Framework, as suggested in the specialized literature and proposed in the few empirical works on SDGs (e.g., Avrampou et al., 2019; Rosati & Faria, 2019a). The sustainability reports were selected from the GRI database in December 2020. A total sample of 4575 verified reports by 4446 organizations were obtained in the first search, among which just 1437 reports (the 31.4% of them) indicated that they included an explicit reference to the SDGs, as shown by a mark in this field in the GRI database. For linguistic reasons, 67 reports were discarded, so that only 1370 reports published either in English, Spanish, French, Portuguese, Italian, or German in 97 countries were considered for this analysis. The reports were published either in 2018 (12% of them), 2019 (38%), or 2020 (50%). Table 1 summarizes the reports/organizations analyzed, their size, their sector of activity, and their location.

The descriptive information included in the sustainability reports was analyzed using a process of systematic categorization that groups information around recurring concepts and issues (Schreier, 2012). More specifically, the analysis of information proceeded followed these steps: extraction and collection of information from the reports; development of the categorization framework; categorization of the retrieved information; analysis and interpretation of information; and selection of illustrative quotations. The information was extracted and collected using general and specialized tools; searches were made using a very diverse set of keywords in different languages (such as “Sustainable Development Goal,” “SDG,” “motivation,” “aim,” “objective,” etc.). As in other works carrying out this type of analysis (e.g., Boiral, 2013; Heras-Saizarbitoria et al., 2020; Macellari et al., 2021), the information obtained from the reports was then analyzed and categorized by two researchers using specialized qualitative data analysis software.⁴

4 | RESULTS

4.1 | The general motivation towards SDG engagement

Most of the companies analyzed were very evasive, if not silent, on the question of their general aim or motivation towards the SDGs in their reports, which was mentioned in less than 10% of the cases. SDGs are increasingly used in sustainability reports and more disclosure on motivation could be expected, among other things because of the reporting principle of materiality of the GRI.

In most cases (around 60% of them) the motivation was directly or indirectly mentioned either in the introductory information about the SDGs or in the introduction to the report—frequently in an introductory letter by the president, the CEO or their equivalent in the organization. Most of the statements on the general motivation towards SDG engagement echoed the CSR-related mainstream idea

TABLE 1 Characteristics of the analyzed sample

Size		Breakdown by continent	
SME	16%	Africa	3%
Large	50%	America	30%
MNE	35%	Asia	19%
Total	100%	Europe	46
		Oceania	2%
		Total	100%
Sectoral breakdown ^a			
Agriculture	2%	Metal Products	2%
Automotive	2%	Mining	3%
Aviation	2%	Non-Profit/Services	1%
Chemicals	4%	Other	22%
Commercial services	2%	Public Agency	1%
Conglomerates	2%	Real State	4%
Construction Materials	2%	Public	6%
Energy	6%	Retailers	1%
Energy utilities	4%	Technology Hardware	2%
Equipment	1%	Telecommunications	3%
Financial services	14%	Textiles and Apparel	2%
Food and beverage products	5%	Tourism / Leisure	2%
Forest & Paper Products	1%	Universities	2%
Healthcare products	3%	Water utilities	1%
Healthcare services	1%		
Household and personal products	1%		
Logistics	1%	Total	100%

Source: prepared by the authors.

^aClassification included in the GRI data-base except for 'Other' which includes the activities coded as 'Other' in the data-base and other less frequent activities in the sample.

of UN that businesses are a “key actor to achieve a sustainable society” and/or highlighted the “prominent role” or “collaborative approach” that might be played by firms in attaining the SDGs. The representatives of the organizations were very functionalist in their descriptions, describing the utility of the SDGs. The following quotes taken from the sustainability reports illustrate this:

Established by the United Nations in 2015, the SDGs aim to create a world without poverty, inequality, unrest and environmental stress. Businesses can play a critical role in providing solutions to these sustainability concerns that can also generate new opportunities. [Firm name omitted] is contributing to these goals across nine areas aligned with our [name omitted] sustainability framework. Our alignment with the SDGs is shown below and indicated in the relevant sections of this report. (Large Chemical firm, Germany)

We consider that we have a role and must contribute in our own measure to the SDGs defined in the United Nations 2030 Agenda. (Large Energy firm, Thailand)

The opportunities generated by the implementation of the Agenda 2030 and the SDGs are highlighted by many companies in an enthusiastic and optimistic tone:

Today the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are being upheld around the world, and momentum is building behind efforts for realizing a sustainable, diversified, and inclusive society. (SME of the Commercial Services, Italy)

The UN SDGs provide the global community with a roadmap for how to combat global challenges related to economic, social and environmental sustainability. As the global leader in access solutions, [firm name omitted] sustainability work is aligned with the objectives of the SDGs. (MNC of the Equipment sector, Germany)

In around a 20% of the cases the ultimate goal is associated with previous activity of the organization in the CSR-field including reference to their main steps or milestones in CSR, such as engagement with self-regulation initiatives, especially the ones proposed by the UN. The following passages are illustrative of this:

We have participated in the UN Global Compact since 2008 and work to achieve the SDGs to ensure respect for the environment, people development and business sustainability. (SME from the Financial Services, Honduras)

[Firm name omitted] is acting according to internationally-agreed standards, such as the Paris Agreement, the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights, and SDGs, as well as expert advice. (MNC of the Automotive sector, Japan)

We launched our CSR strategy, a roadmap whose fundamental pillars are the ISO 26000, the principles of the Global Compact and the SDGs, together with the World Tourism Organization's Global Code of Ethics for Tourism. (Large firm from Tourism/Leisure, Spain)

In around of a 15% of the reports refer to the ultimate objective or potential of the SDGs but embedded in specific national/regional reference-plan(s) aligning the effort of the organization with it/them:

The Company supports the implementation of SDGs that were adopted by 193 United Nations member countries including India. We are convinced that by utilizing our resources coupled with expertise and professionalism, we can accelerate progress towards sustainability. (Large firm from the Equipment sector, India)

The SDGs set a global action agenda with the purpose of improving the welfare of present and future generations. There are 17 goals as a form of sustainable development towards 2030. Indonesia has also issued Presidential Decree no. 59 of 2017, which regulates the Implementation of Achieving Sustainable Development Goals. The real actions of [firm name omitted], which are summarized on material topics, are a form of support for [firm name omitted] to achieve the SDGs. (Large firm from the Financial Services, Indonesia)

In line with the functionalist approach, few companies (4%) underlined the “market opportunities” associated with SDGs as a key to their introduction in the organization:

The SDGs and their underlying targets reveal new market opportunities for innovative companies such as [firm name omitted]. (MNC of the Mining sector, Brazil)

At [firm name omitted] we believe that social and environmental responsibility are implicit in the pursuit of economic sustainability. A company committed and focused on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) is a profitable company. (MNC of the Commercial Services, France)

Contributing to SDG opens up significant business opportunities, optimizes client relationships, improves conditions of access to capital and investor relations, increases employee

motivation and the attractiveness of the company to capture talent. (Large firm of the Tourism/Leisure sector, Spain)

Some companies (4%) also underlined an idea close to the concept of global corporate citizenship, which has been conceptually associated with the SDGs in the literature (e.g., Rendtorff, 2020). Those companies refer to their engagement with the SDGs by evoking their potential to act as a leading stakeholder in global society, together with public authorities (e.g., national governments) and the civil society. Even small organizations sometimes claimed to have leadership potential in this regard. Here are some extracts that illustrate this perspective:

At [name of the corporation omitted] we joined the global community as partners in contributing to Uganda's achievement of its Sustainable Development goals. (SME of the Equipment sector, Uganda)

Our development direction is built around the UN SDGs, and through the promotion of the widespread application of technology, we hope to help humanity find innovative solutions to the environmental and social problems we face and improve humanity's quality of life. (MNC of the Telecommunications' sector, Taiwan)

In order to help change the world together, we need to make a sincere, transparent and firm commitment to the different groups with which we interact and to the SDGs. (MNC of the Commercial Services, France)

Very few companies (2%) had a reactive or defensive response to SDGs, portraying them as a framework to evaluate risks and react with specific strategic actions. Similarly, very few organizations underlined potential conflicts of interest and tensions in balancing SDGs and corporate objectives. The following excerpt illustrates this minority approach:

The right balance is an important dimension in our approach, and it is not always easy, given the sometimes-inherent tensions in the pursuit of various Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). For example, there are instances where development and social goals are in conflict. Net impact assessment is therefore integral to determine if an industry creates overall positive or negative impact. (SME of the Textile and Apparel, Hong Kong)

Surprisingly, only a few organizations (around 4%) included more elaborate and nuanced statements about their ultimate goal in engaging with the SDGs. The following quote—found in the report of an award-winning company for its engagement with the SDGs in its industry—is typical of such more developed reflections:

The decision to commit to SDGs reflects the [firm name omitted] willingness to find common ground with public



authorities with regard to long-term sustainable local development. (SME of the Commercial Services, Sweden)

4.2 | The prioritization of the engagement with the SDGs

The SDGs were not given a high priority in the analyzed sample. Only around 23% of the organizations (330 reports) made a clear selection of the most relevant SDGs. In these cases, priority was not specified in a meaningful way, as suggested by Mhlanga et al. (2018). With very few exceptions (around 5% of cases), there is no clear explanation of why a specific set of SDGs is considered relevant, or whether any stakeholders were consulted in selecting certain SDGs as priorities.

The following excerpts illustrate how organizations present the prioritization of goals in a rather simple way, in most of the cases by referring to efficiency considerations:

Our focus remains on the six SDGs where we believe we have the greatest impact and the greatest opportunity to make a real and lasting difference: SDGs 7, 8, 9, 12, 13 and 15. (MNC of the Equipment sector, UK)

We have assigned priority to those SDGs that could be significantly impacted by our business activities. (SME of the Financial services, Sweden)

Like many companies, we are on a journey to embed the SDGs into our business planning and activities, with a focus on those SDGs that most closely align to the areas where we have the greatest influence and impact. (MNC of the Building sector, Ireland)

At [firm name omitted], we focus our efforts on four SDGs where we can have the highest impact. (Large firm, Conglomerate, from USA)

Some organizations (around 14%) referred to their resources and capabilities and their sectoral contingencies, or the type of operations they carry out, to explain their selection of SDGs, but a few organizations approach this topic with a more contextualized and empathetic approach. Here are some examples to illustrate the latter:

To determine the sustainability context, we took into consideration the progress made on the SDGs in the countries in which our operations and projects are located. (Large firm from Logistics, Canada)

In prioritizing our SDGs, we take into account the needs and demands of our local stakeholders, especially those of the communities with whom we plan and deploy sustainable development action plans. (Large firm from Mining, Chile)

According to the GRI principles, reporting organizations shall define their “sustainability context” (GRI, 2020), so it is to be expected

that they would provide more contextual explanation on the adoption of SDGs.

Most companies do not put a clear focus on key SDGs. In many cases, they focus on some of them in order to establish a link, for example, between the SDGs and their results, activities and/or indicators (see the next subsection), or to illustrate aspects or items included in their report (e.g., with the respective SDG icon), but with no explicit prioritization. This finding is also in line with the results of van der Waal and Thijssens (2020).

Figure 1 summarizes the SDGs most mentioned by the organizations that established an explicit prioritization. As shown in this figure, SDG 8 (decent work and economic growth), SDG 12 (responsible consumption and production) and SDG 13 (climate action) were mentioned most. SDG 14 (life below water) and SDG 2 (zero hunger) were mentioned least. This finding confirms the results obtained in other studies (Mhlanga et al., 2018; Van Zanten & Van Tulder, 2018) with more limited samples.

Focusing on the less prioritized goals—namely SDG 14 (life below water) and SDG 2 (zero hunger)—as they seem to be the most remote from mainstream CSR and sustainability practices, reference to these goals was most often explicable in terms of the company's. SDG 2 was usually mentioned by organizations in the food and beverage sector and SDG 14 by companies that directly affect marine pollution.

Similarly, as clear exceptions of the tendency towards superficial prioritization, four organizations explained their procedure of prioritization in their reports, giving the steps in their consultation with external stakeholders (self-made or based on external resources) and linking them to their materiality analysis. One of these organizations gave the following account:

We obtain feedback from stakeholders on a regular basis. Based on our materiality assessment, we identified where our biggest risks to people and the environment were located (...) and where our biggest contribution through our products, services or investments (...), could be achieved in relation to the SDGs. Based on this analysis, we report on the 4 SDGs identified. (MNE, Technology Hardware, USA)

4.3 | The operationalization of the engagement with the SDGs

Surprisingly, a significant number of the organizations analyzed made no reference or only an extremely superficial reference to the SDGs in their reports. Around the 5% of the organizations did not mention SDGs at all and 50% of the sample mentioned them very briefly two or three times.

Among the organizations that disclosed more detailed information about the SDGs (44% of the sample), operationalization of the commitment to SDGs was very weak. Here is a brief summary of some of the main figures obtained from the analysis:

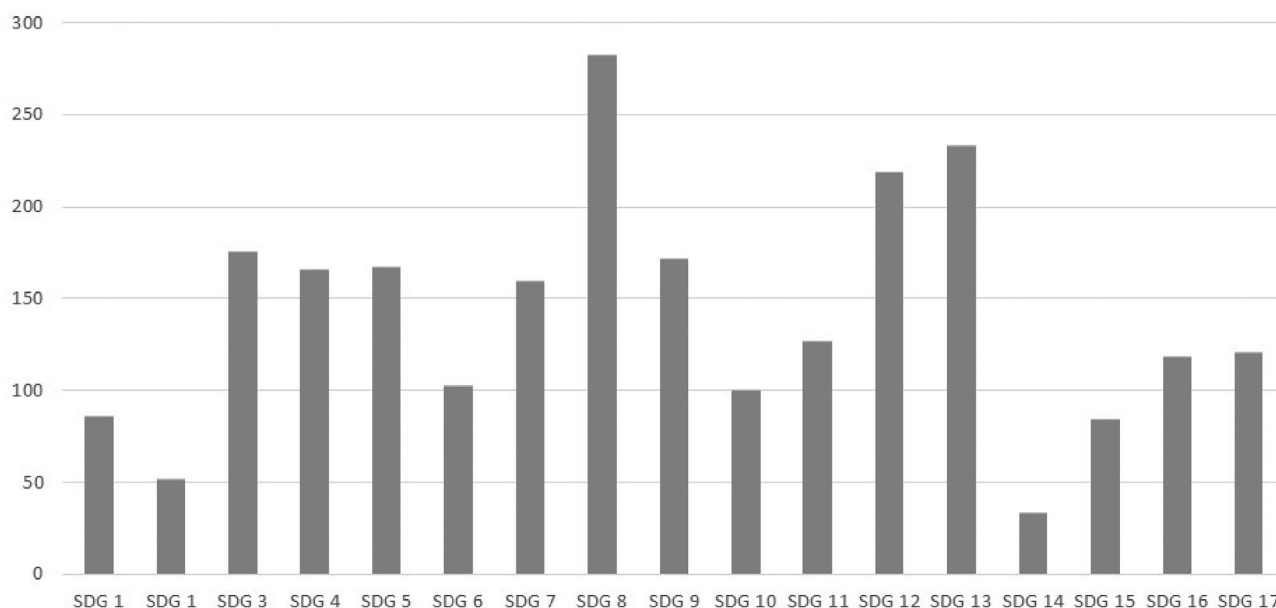


FIGURE 1 Sustainable development goals (SDGs) as prioritized by organizations in their sustainability reports. Source: Prepared by the authors. The figure summarizes the SDGs mentioned by the organizations that established a clear prioritization ($n = 330$)

1. Only a 29% of the organizations made any kind of association between their overall strategy and/or general/specific objectives and the objectives and/or targets of the SDGs, despite tools such as the SDG Compass underline that SDGs should be an integral part of firms' full set of financial, strategic and operational goals (SDG Compass, 2015).
2. Around 11% of the organizations referred specifically to the SDGs in their sustainability report.
3. Around a 17% of the organizations included a table showing the correspondence between the objectives and targets of the SDGs and the objectives and targets of the organization.
4. Only 73 organizations (5% of the sample) included tables in their sustainability reports to show the correspondence between the material aspects identified and the specific objectives and targets of the SDGs.
5. Only 60 organizations (4% of the sample) included specific detailed examples of initiatives aimed to engage with the SDGs.
6. Only 10 companies disclosed information about the integration of the SDGs in the presentation of specific indicators defined by the GRI.
7. Only around 30 organizations (2% of the sample) included key performance indicators (KPIs) related to the SDGs.

Regarding (1), when it was established, the association between overall strategy and/or general/specific objectives of the organization and the objectives and/or targets of the SDGs was described in rather different way. Many organizations made a very bold and general connection between the SDGs and their strategic lines and/or general/specific objectives, while others gave a more detailed analysis against each SDG, taking into account the potential positive and negative impacts of the organization on each of the SDGs and the specific

internal and external stakeholders affected, with a reference to key SDG sub-targets and cross linkages. In a few examples of best practice, this type of analysis was included in a specific report or link to the organizations' website devoted to the SDG analysis where they included this information as SDG indexes, SDG dashboards, SDGs maps or SDG materiality maps.

Regarding (3), in some cases relevant information on methodological aspects were disclosed, such as information related to the stakeholder consultation process that defined objectives and targets. This could be seen as an evidence of a greater integration and operationalization of the SDGs. But in most of the cases, a more or less well developed cross-tabulation was presented (sometimes called an "SDG index"), including an index to the pages of the sustainability report where references to the targets for SDGs relevant to the organization were made. Some organizations included tables referring to specific targets of the SDGs, cross-referenced with GRI indicators.

Regarding (5), the number of organizations that included detailed concrete examples of engagement with the SDGs was very small. A few of these organizations included a specific section in their report linking the report to other sources of corporate information on the most important actions in the framework of each of the prioritized SDGs. Other organizations included reference to the SDGs associated with specific outcomes or performance measures. This was explained in a very superficial way, if at all. In a number of cases, an icon of the SDGs was associated with certain results or performance, with little or no explanation.

Finally, with regards to the use of KPIs related to SDGs (7), it is surprising to find that very few of the analyzed organizations defined clear KPIs associated with SDGs, despite this issue being identified as essential for setting goals and targets that can be used as the basis for driving, monitoring, and communicating progress (GRI, 2015).

Organizations also cherry-picked among those activities already underway to assign them to specific SDGs. The following passages illustrate this:

These initiatives that we associate with SDG 13, are well rooted in [firm name omitted], as evidenced by the fact that they were implemented more than a decade ago. (MNC from Technology Hardware, Germany)

This programme [associated to SDG 2 and SDG 13 among others], [...] raises awareness of a range of topics including sustainable development, responsible consumption and zero hunger. (Large firm from Commercial Services, Spain)

As a measure of a more developed commitment to the SDGs, very few organizations in the analyzed sample reported the use of specific tools to operationalize engagement with SDGs. Only 40 companies (around 3% of the sample) used the SDG Compass, and only two organizations used the SDG Action Manager tool. The following passages relate to the rationale for using the SDG Compass:

With SDG Compass we map material issues and stakeholders, we work on them in relation to each of the SDGs, we determined where to place emphasis, how to work on them in relation to the targets of each one, what results are obtained from the proposed actions and what would be the best communication strategy to generate engagement. (SME from Commercial Services, Argentina)

To materialize the commitment to the SDGs, [firm name omitted] adopted the SDG Compass protocol in order to facilitate the understanding of its contribution to the compliance. (MNC from the Construction Materials, Colombia)

In 2019, we started the process of applying the SDG Compass by evaluating how well our responsible development approach aligns with the SDGs and where opportunities might exist for improving alignment with the SDGs. (Large firm from Agriculture, Indonesia)

Figure 2 summarizes the main trends of this analysis. The category of “Nonexistent” is related to the percentage of organizations that did not mention the SDGs at all. “Extremely low” engagement is related to the organizations that mentioned them only two or three times. The “Very low” category is related to (1) and “Low” is related to (2). The “Intermediate” category is related to the other cases (3–7).

In summary, apart from a very small percentage of organizations that operationalize the SDGs, at least in the information disclosed in their reports, in a rather developed way, most organizations studied have an extremely superficial approach to the SDGs. In the best cases, there is cherry-picking of the SDGs, with organizations describing very superficial and rather elastic strategies, lines, actions and/or results linked to the SDGs. In other cases, which represent the majority, the SDGs only serve to add color and fancy icons to reports suggestive of impression management and SDG-washing. The icons of the SDGs are shown in the sustainability reports as a “design complement” (i.e., as bullets in sections) hinting at a linkage, but with no specific explanation.

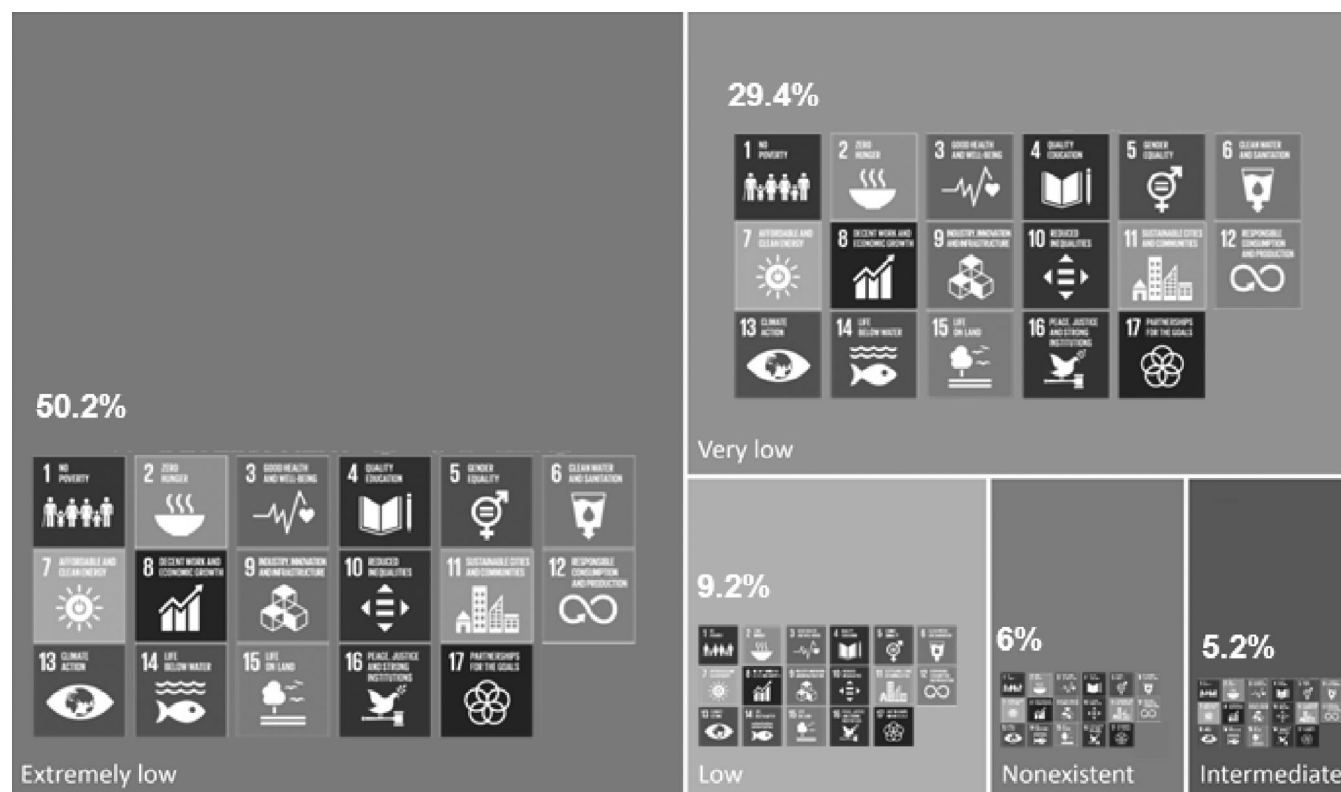


FIGURE 2 Integration and operationalization of sustainable development goals in big figures. Source: Prepared by the authors

5 | DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

Based on a qualitative analysis of 1370 sustainability reports explicitly linked to SDGs published by organizations from across the world, this study draws a rather disappointing picture of the engagement with the SDGs.

Most of the companies analyzed were very evasive or silent about their approach to tackling the SDGs in their reports. And when an explicit reference was made, a rather simple functionalistic and deterministic discourse, without references to any meaningful reflection, was presented. A similar pattern was found by Waal and Thijssens (2020) for a limited sample of 30 reports. In most cases—over 80%—the prioritization of SDGs was not explained, or where it was, evidence of a meaningful process of prioritization was rarely found. The organizational operationalization of the SDGs was also superficial—or non-existent—in the majority of the cases. With the notable exception of a very small number of organizations that integrate the SDGs in their reports in a developed way by referring, for example, to specific strategies, goals, targets, indicators, actions or results, most organizations have an extremely superficial approach to the SDGs. Given that one of the main objectives of the SDGs is to provide objectives and targets related to 17 critical issues, the very low percentage of organizations disclosing information on specific indicators related to SDGs reflects their superficial engagement with these goals.

In the best cases, there is a cherry-picking use of the SDGs in which organizations identify, in a very superficial and rather elastic way, strategies, lines, actions and/or results—most frequently already embedded in the CSR practices for years—linked to a set of SDGs. In the majority of the cases, the SDGs only serve to add color and fancy icons to the reports in a trend towards “SDG icon-picking” that may point to impression management and SDG-washing. As pointed out by Siegel and Lima (2020), “the fact that the SDGs are so broad has given ample room for cherry-picking and given rise to a form of sustainability metonymy, whereby meeting selected targets of choice (e.g., economic growth, eliminating global hunger) are taken to signify conformity to the whole of the 2030 Agenda, irrespective of other goals and targets disregarded in the process.” (p. 2).

These findings are consistent with and complementary to some recent empirical works published in the scholarly literature reviewed in this article. Companies engage with the SDGs as a way to strengthen their social legitimacy and link current activity to the SDGs as a mode of impression management (Macellari et al., 2021; van der Waal & Thijssens, 2020), two strategies that might be associated with bluewashing or SDG-washing. Overall, impression management practices are intended to enhance the positive aspects of a company's achievements and obfuscate more negative aspects in order to influence their image among stakeholders (Cho et al., 2010; Diouf & Boiral, 2017). Explicit reference to the SDGs and the frequent use of the pictograms used by the UN allows reporting organizations to project an image of social responsibility and alignment with sustainability issues that are of public interest and widely publicized. The lack of substance in the information about how the SDGs are operationalized

(virtual absence of specific indicators and meaningful examples) is a way to obfuscate the rather symbolic and superficial nature of the measures in this area. These findings are consistent with the literature on the neo-institutional approach to corporate sustainability commitment, which has shown the disconnect between the official optimistic rhetoric of organizations, which is primarily intended to meet stakeholder expectations, and actual internal practices (Boiral & Gendron, 2011; Jamali, 2010; Marquis & Qian, 2014; Perego & Kolk, 2012).

This work contributes to the literature in three complementary ways. First, it contributes to the scarce empirical literature that analyzes the implications of SDGs for companies by analyzing a large sample of organizations ($n = 1370$) explicitly committed to SDGs. Second, it contributes to the incipient and emerging branch of the practitioner (e.g., Mhlanga et al., 2018) and scholarly literature that questions the prevailing positive opinion about the engagement of organizations in self-regulated CSR initiatives. The scholarly literature on SDGs that takes a general neo-institutional approach has recently identified the prevalence of bluewashing or SDG-washing in CSR self-regulation initiatives, such as the SDGs (e.g., van der Waal and Thijssens, 2020; Macellari et al., 2021; Nishitani et al., 2021). In line with the critical literature on the subject (Boiral et al., 2019; Perego & Kolk, 2012), the results of this study raise questions about the credibility and usefulness of current sustainability reporting practices in demonstrating organizational accountability. The study also shows that the reporting principles put forward by the recognized standards in this field—in particular the GRI—are not seriously applied by reporting organizations. This is particularly the case for principles such as completeness (sufficiently detailed coverage of key issues), materiality (relevance of information to understanding impacts), and accuracy (existence of sufficiently precise indicators to assess performance). The virtual absence of information on the rationale for the use of the SDGs, their links to the material aspects of organizations, and specific indicators to measure performance in relation to them highlight the evasive application, at best, of the GRI principles and confirm the critical studies on this issue (Behnam & MacLean, 2011; Boiral, 2013; Diouf & Boiral, 2017; Jamali, 2010).

Third, this study sheds light on the practical side of sustainability reporting by organizations that claim a commitment to SDGs, suggesting implications for managers, policy makers, and other relevant stakeholders. Public decision makers and policy makers—at the global, the meso and the local level—need to rethink policies that promote self-regulation initiatives for CSR, such as the SDGs. But beyond this general conclusion, the parallels between research that has shown fads and fashions in management (e.g., Abrahamson, 1996; Piazza & Abrahamson, 2020) and actions of global institutional entrepreneurs such as the UN—with the successive launch of the MDGs, the UNGC and the SDGs—should cause many public policy makers to reflect.

Similarly, as underlined in the literature on other self-regulatory initiatives (e.g., Heras-Saizarbitoria et al., 2020; Testa et al., 2018), the findings also underline the importance of establishing appropriate programmes for public evaluation to analyze the real impact of this type of self-regulation initiative for CSR. Among other things, monitoring the lack of consistency between the substantive changes

required by the adoption of the SDGs and the symbolic way in which they are covered in sustainability reports raises questions about the verification mechanisms implemented to improve the credibility of information. Although sustainability reports are increasingly verified by external auditors (KPMG, 2017), the rigor and usefulness of these verifications have been seriously questioned in various studies. These studies have highlighted the conflicts of interest of the auditors, their lack of training in sustainability issues and the superficiality of the assurance process (Boiral et al., 2019; Boiral & Heras-Saizarbitoria, 2020; Perego & Kolk, 2012). Given the critical importance of the issues covered by the SDGs and their public interest, sustainability disclosure practices should be better regulated, including in terms of reliability of information and implementation of verification mechanisms conducted by qualified auditors. The involvement of government-appointed experts and external stakeholders—including government representatives and NGOs—in the verification of SDG disclosures would probably give greater credibility to reports. The need to foster specific frameworks to develop SDG engagement and improve SDG assessment opportunities, as proposed by Forestier and Kim (2020), is pressing.

Another implication is the need to rethink public policies associated with this type of self-regulatory initiative in CSR, at least for certain industrial entrepreneurs, some of the most enthusiastic supporters of this type of initiatives (e.g., consultancy firms, business associations, and public relations firms). For many stakeholders who are really concerned about environmental and social issues, including many NGOs and civil society associations, the tendency to superficial engagement with the SDGs—or SDG-washing—and the lack of concrete practices to engage with beneficial targets may be used as leverage to exert pressure on organizations to produce more substantive CSR practices in a structured and detailed way. Managers of organizations interested in a real enhancement of their CSR and sustainability practices might find the findings of the analysis important in order to be aware of SDG-washing practices and to improve their organizations' engagement with the SDGs.

This study has limitations due to its exploratory nature and its methodological approach. Like the few empirical studies on the organizational impact of the SDGs, this study is based on secondary and publicly available information contained in sustainability reports. This information is therefore related to the “talk” of the organizations rather than to the “walk” or actions they perform. As underlined by Rosati and Faria (2019a), this methodology may be biased in assessing actual organizational performance against the SDGs. Therefore, Macellari et al. (2021) suggested, further research on organizations is needed to examine the practical implications of engagement with the SDGs. As has also been indicated by several works in the field of CSR self-regulatory initiatives (e.g., Boiral, 2007; Boiral et al., 2017; Testa et al., 2018), social desirability bias should be considered when conducting field work with managers and CSR experts.

The limitations of this work suggest avenues for further research. Empirical qualitative and quantitative works that analyze organizations' engagement with the SDGs in diverse organizational and

sociocultural contexts should be fostered. In order to avoid social desirability bias, studies should consult internal (e.g., employees, managers) and external stakeholders (e.g., consultancy, NGOs, consumer associations). Focusing on sustainability reports—keeping all the mentioned limitations in mind—it would be interesting to deepen the analysis of engagement of exemplary organizations with the SDGs, especially, as Mhlenga et al. (2018) suggest, regarding their SDG ambitions, the actions they take and targets they set as a result of the engagement with the SDGs.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This study is an output of the Research Group 15/176 of the Basque University System (funded by the Basque Autonomous Government) and the Canada Research Chair on the Internalization of Sustainable Development and Organizational Responsibility.

ORCID

Iñaki Heras-Saizarbitoria  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-9337-1374>

ENDNOTES

- ¹ Specially in the field of public administration (Annesi et al., 2021).
- ² In sustainability reporting materiality is a quality of the disclosed information to cover organization's significant economic, environmental, and social impacts, or that would substantively influence the assessments and decisions by stakeholders (GRI, 2015).
- ³ Indicates that the report was verified either through the GRI Standards Report Registration System or the Registration Form by a representative of the reporting organization or by a third-party authorized by the reporting organization (GRI, 2020).
- ⁴ QDA Miner qualitative data analysis was used, among other software.

REFERENCES

- Abrahamson, E. (1996). Management fashion. *Academy of Management Review*, 21(1), 254–285.
- Accenture. (2016). “Agenda 2030: A Window of Opportunity Accenture Strategy”, [Retrieved from: <https://www.accenture.com/t20161216T041642Zw/us-en/acnmedia/Accenture/next-gen-2/insight-ungc-ceo-study-page/Accenture-UN-Global-Compact-Accenture-Strategy-CEO-Study-2016.pdf>] (accessed March 8, 2021).
- Alonso-Almeida, M., Llach, J., & Marimon, F. (2014). A closer look at the ‘Global Reporting Initiatives sustainability reporting as a tool to implement environmental and social policies: A worldwide sector analysis. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 21(6), 318–335.
- Annesi, N., Battaglia, M., Gragnani, P., & Iraldo, F. (2021). Integrating the 2030 agenda at the municipal level: Multilevel pressures and institutional shift. *Land Use Policy*, 105, 105424.
- Avrampou, A., Skouloudis, A., Iliopoulos, G., & Khan, N. (2019). Advancing the sustainable development goals: Evidence from leading European banks. *Sustainable Development*, 27(4), 743–757.
- Bansal, P., Gao, J., & Qureshi, I. (2014). The extensiveness of corporate social and environmental commitment across firms over time. *Organization Studies*, 35(7), 949–966.
- Battaglia, M., Annesi, N., Calabrese, M., & Frey, M. (2020). Do agenda 2030 and sustainable development goals act at local and operational levels? Evidence from a case study in a large energy company in Italy. *Business Strategy & Development*, 3(4), 603–614.

- Bebbington, J., & Unerman, J. (2018). Achieving the United Nations sustainable development goals: An enabling role for accounting research. *Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal*, 31(1), 2–24.
- Behnam, M., & MacLean, T. L. (2011). Where is the accountability in international accountability standards?: A decoupling perspective. *Business Ethics Quarterly*, 21(1), 45–72.
- Bennich, T., Weitz, N., & Carlsen, H. (2020). Deciphering the scientific literature on SDG interactions: A review and reading guide. *Science of the Total Environment*, 728, 138405.
- Berliner, D., & Prakash, A. (2015). “Bluewashing” the firm? Voluntary regulations, program design, and member compliance with the United Nations global compact. *Policy Studies Journal*, 43(1), 115–138.
- Beyne, J. (2020). Designing and implementing sustainability: An integrative framework for implementing the sustainable development goals. *European Journal of Sustainable Development*, 9(3), 1–12.
- Boiral, O., & Gendron, Y. (2011). Sustainable development and certification practices: Lessons learned and prospects. *Business Strategy and the Environment*, 20(5), 331–347.
- Boiral, O. (2013). Sustainability reports as simulacra? A counter-account of a and a+ GRI reports. *Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal*, 26(7), 1036–1071.
- Boiral, O., Heras-Saizarbitoria, I., & Testa, F. (2017). SA8000 as CSR-washing? The role of stakeholder pressures. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 24(1), 57–70.
- Boiral, O. (2007). Corporate greening through ISO 14001: a rational myth?. *Organization Science*, 18(1), 127–146.
- Boiral, O., Heras-Saizarbitoria, I., & Brotherton, M. C. (2019). Assessing and improving the quality of sustainability reports: The auditors’ perspective. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 155(3), 703–721.
- Boiral, O., & Heras-Saizarbitoria, I. (2020). Sustainability reporting assurance: Creating stakeholder accountability through hyperreality?. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, in press. Volume 243, 10 January 2020, 118596.
- Caiaado, R. G. G., Leal Filho, W., Quelhas, O. L. G., de Mattos Nascimento, D. L., & Ávila, L. V. (2018). A literature-based review on potentials and constraints in the implementation of the sustainable development goals. *Journal of cleaner production*, 198, 1276–1288.
- Chiarini, A. (2017). Environmental policies for evaluating suppliers’ performance based on GRI indicators. *Business Strategy and the Environment*, 26(1), 98–111.
- Cho, C. H., Roberts, R. W., & Patten, D. M. (2010). The language of US corporate environmental disclosure. *Accounting, Organizations and Society*, 35(4), 431–443.
- Curtó-Pagès, F., Ortega-Rivera, E., Castellón-Durán, M., & Jané-Llopis, E. (2021). Coming in from the Cold: A Longitudinal Analysis of SDG Reporting Practices by Spanish Listed Companies Since the Approval of the 2030 Agenda. *Sustainability*, 13(3), 1178.
- Demuijnck, G., & Fasterling, B. (2016). The social license to operate. *Journal of business ethics*, 4, 675–685.
- Diaz-Sarachaga, J. M. (2021). Shortcomings in reporting contributions towards the sustainable development goals. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 28(4), 1299–1312.
- Diouf, D., & Boiral, O. (2017). The quality of sustainability reports and impression management: A stakeholder perspective. *Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal*, 30(3), 643–667.
- Elalfy, A., Weber, O., & Geobey, S. (2021). The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs): a rising tide lifts all boats? Global reporting implications in a post SDGs world. *Journal of Applied Accounting Research*, 22(3), 557–575.
- Forestier, O., & Kim, R. E. (2020). Cherry-picking the sustainable development goals: Goal prioritization by national governments and implications for global governance. *Sustainable Development*, 28(5), 1269–1278.
- García-Sánchez, I. M., Aibar-Guzmán, B., Aibar-Guzmán, C., & Rodríguez-Ariza, L. (2020). “Sell” recommendations by analysts in response to business communication strategies concerning the Sustainable Development Goals and the SDG compass. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 255, 120194.
- Garayar, A., Heras-Saizarbitoria, I., & Boiral, O. (2016). Adoption of the UN global compact in Spanish banking: A case study. *Journal of Public Affairs*, 16(4), 359–367.
- Giddens, M. (2018). The SDGs Are An Opportunity, Not Just A Challenge, Forbes [Retrieved from: <https://www.forbes.com/sites/michelegiddens/2018/05/24/the-sdgs-are-an-opportunity-not-just-a-challenge/?sh=223509df3ef5>]. (accessed March 8, 2021).
- Gresko, K. E., & Banik, D. (2018). Business and the SDGs: From rainbow washing to reality. Centre for Development and the Environment. University of Oslo. Retrieved from: <https://www.sum.uio.no/english/sdg/blog/team/from-rainbow-washing-to-reality.html> (accessed March 8, 2021).
- GRI United Nations Global Compact, & WBCSD. (2015). SDG Compass: The Guide for Business Action on the SDGs. Retrieved from: <https://database.globalreporting.org/>.
- Haufler, V. *A public role for the private sector: Industry self-regulation in a global economy*. New York City: Carnegie Endowment; 2013.
- Haufler, V. *Industry self-regulation in a global economy. A public role for the private sector*. New York, NY: Carnegie Endowment.
- Heras-Saizarbitoria, I., & Boiral, O. (2013). ISO 9001 and ISO 14001: Towards a research agenda on management system standards. *International Journal of Management Reviews*, 15(1), 47–65.
- Heras-Saizarbitoria, I., Boiral, O., & Díaz de Junguitu, A. (2020). Environmental management certification and environmental performance: Greening or greenwashing? *Business Strategy and the Environment*, 29(6), 2829–2841.
- Izzo, M. F., Ciaburri, M., & Tiscini, R. (2020). The challenge of sustainable development goal reporting: The first evidence from Italian listed companies. *Sustainability*, 12(8), 3494.
- Jamali, D. (2010). MNCs and international accountability standards through an institutional lens: Evidence of symbolic conformity or decoupling. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 95(4), 617–640.
- Johnsson, F., Karlsson, I., Rootzén, J., Ahlback, A., & Gustavsson, M. (2020). The framing of a sustainable development goals assessment in decarbonizing the construction industry—Avoiding “Greenwashing”. *Renewable and sustainable energy reviews*, 131, 110029.
- Jones, P., Hillier, D., & Comfort, D. (2016). The sustainable development goals and business. *International Journal of Sales, Retailing and Marketing*, 5(2), 38–48.
- Kell, G. (2005). The global compact selected experiences and reflections. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 59(1), 69–79.
- King, A. A., & Lenox, M. J. (2000). Industry self-regulation without sanctions: The chemical industry’s responsible care program. *Academy of management journal*, 43(4), 698–716.
- KPMG. *KPMG The Road Ahead: KPMG Survey of Corporate Responsibility Reporting 2017*. Zurich: KPMG; 2017.
- Macellari, M., Yuriev, A., Testa, F., & Boiral, O. (2021). Exploring bluewashing practices of alleged sustainability leaders through a counter-accounting analysis. *Environmental Impact Assessment Review*, 86, 106489.
- Mansell, P., Philbin, S. P., & Broyd, T. (2020). Development of a new business model to measure organizational and project-level SDG impact—Case study of a water utility company. *Sustainability*, 12(16), 6413.
- Marquis, C., & Qian, C. (2014). Corporate social responsibility reporting in China: Symbol or substance?. *Organization science*, 25(1), 127–148.
- Mhlanga, R., Gneiting, U., & Agarwal, N. (2018). *Walking the talk: Assessing companies’ progress from SDG rhetoric to action*. Oxfam Discussion Papers.
- Mio, C., Panfilo, S., & Blundo, B. (2020). Sustainable development goals and the strategic role of business: A systematic literature review. *Business Strategy and the Environment*, 29, 3220–3245.
- Montiel, I., Cuervo-Cazurra, A., Park, J. et al. (2021). Implementing the United Nations’ Sustainable Development Goals in international business. *J Int Bus Stud*, 52, 999–1030.



- Moneva, J. M., Archel, P., & Correa, C. (2006). GRI and the camouflaging of corporate unsustainability. *Accounting Forum*, 30(2), 121–137.
- Moratis, L., & Melissen, F. (2018). How do the sustainable development goals question rather than inform corporate sustainability? *Resources, Conservation & Recycling*, 141, 253–254.
- Moratis, L., & Brandt, S. (2017). Corporate stakeholder responsiveness? Exploring the state and quality of GRI-based stakeholder engagement disclosures of European firms. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 24(4), 312–325.
- Nishitani, K., Nguyen, T. B. H., Trinh, T. Q., Wu, Q., & Kokubu, K. (2021). Are corporate environmental activities to meet Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) simply greenwashing? An empirical study of vietnamese companies from the stakeholder management perspective (No. DP2021-12).
- Ordóñez-Ponce, E., & Khare, A. (2021). GRI 300 as a measurement tool for the United Nations sustainable development goals: Assessing the impact of car makers on sustainability. *Journal of Environmental Planning and Management*, 64(1), 47–75.
- Patten, D. M. (2002). The relation between environmental performance and environmental disclosure: A research note. *Accounting, Organizations and Society*, 27(8), 763–773.
- Pedersen, C. S. (2018). The UN sustainable development goals (SDGs) are a great gift to business! *Procedia Cirp*, 69, 21–24.
- Perego, P., & Kolk, A. (2012). Multinationals' accountability on sustainability: The evolution of third-party assurance of sustainability reports. *Journal of business ethics*, 110(2), 173–190.
- Piazza, A., & Abrahamson, E. (2020). Fads and fashions in management practices: Taking stock and looking forward. *International Journal of Management Reviews*, 22(3), 264–286.
- Pizzi, S., Rosati, F., & Venturelli, A. (2021). The determinants of business contribution to the 2030 agenda: Introducing the SDG reporting score. *Business Strategy and the Environment*, 30(1), 404–421.
- Pradhan, P., Costa, L., Rybski, D., Lucht, W., & Kropp, J. P. (2017). A systematic study of sustainable development goal (SDG) interactions. *Earth's Future*, 5(11), 1169–1179.
- PwC Pricewaterhouse Coopers. (2015). Making it your business: Engaging with the Sustainable Development Goals. London: PwC. [Retrieved from: <https://www.pwc.es/es/publicaciones/gestion-empresarial/assets/encuesta-pwc-desarrollo-sostenible.pdf> (accessed March 8, 2021).
- Rasche, A. (2009). "A necessary supplement" what the United Nations global compact is and is not. *Business & Society*, 48(4), 511–537.
- Rendtorff, J. D. (2020). Corporate citizenship, stakeholder management and sustainable development goals (SDGs) in financial institutions and capital markets. *Journal of Capital Markets Studies*, 4(1), 47–59.
- Rosati, F., & Faria, L. G. (2019a). Addressing the SDGs in sustainability reports: The relationship with institutional factors. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 215, 1312–1326.
- Rosati, F., & Faria, L. G. D. (2019b). Business contribution to the sustainable development agenda: Organizational factors related to early adoption of SDG reporting. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 26(3), 588–597.
- Schreier, M. (2012). *Qualitative content analysis in practice*. Sage Publications.
- Scott, L. (2017). *Director, global sustainability*. PwC Retrieved from <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/services/sustainability/sustainable-development-goals/sdg-research-results.html>
- Siegel, K. M., & Lima, M. G. B. (2020). When international sustainability frameworks encounter domestic politics: The sustainable development goals and agri-food governance in South America. *World Development*, 135, 105053.
- Silva, S. (2021). Corporate contributions to the sustainable development goals: An empirical analysis informed by legitimacy theory. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 292(125962), 425–439.
- Spraul, K., & Thaler, J. (2019). Partnering for good? An analysis of how to achieve sustainability-related outcomes in public-private partnerships. *Business Research*, 13(2), 485–511.
- Sullivan, C. (2018). What is SDG-Washing, and How Can Your Business Avoid It? Retrieved from: <https://caterinasullivan.medium.com/what-is-sdg-washing-and-how-can-your-business-avoid-it-df1d7cedeb10> (accessed March 8, 2021).
- Testa, F., Boiral, O., & Heras-Saizarbitoria, I. (2018). Improving CSR performance by hard and soft means: The role of organizational citizenship behaviours and the internalization of CSR standards. *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 25(5), 853–865.
- Van der Waal, J. W., & Thijssens, T. (2020). Corporate involvement in sustainable development goals: Exploring the territory. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 252, 119625.
- Van Zanten, J. A., & Van Tulder, R. (2018). Multinational enterprises and the sustainable development goals: An institutional approach to corporate engagement. *Journal of International Business Policy*, 1(3–4), 208–233.
- Vildåsen, S. S. (2018). Corporate sustainability in practice: An exploratory study of the sustainable development goals (SDG s). *Business Strategy & Development*, 1(4), 256–264.
- Vogel, D. (2008). Private global business regulation. *Annu. Rev. Polit. Sci.*, 11, 261–282.
- Williams, O. F. (2004). The UN global compact: The challenge and the promise. *Business Ethics Quarterly*, 14(4), 755–774.

How to cite this article: Heras-Saizarbitoria, I., Urbieta, L., & Boiral, O. (2022). Organizations' engagement with sustainable development goals: From cherry-picking to SDG-washing? *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, 29(2), 316–328. <https://doi.org/10.1002/csr.2202>